

GOING BEYOND

TEXT: Ephesians 3:20 (NKJV) *“Now to Him who is able to do exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that works in us.”*

INTRO: God has given me a prophetic word of “Going Beyond” for CT Church in 2017. There are three areas we are going to focus our efforts to “Go Beyond”:

- Making disciples...
- Empowering individuals...
- Serving each other and the community...

To “Go Beyond” we must first become discontent with the status quo. Very few people or organizations make progress when they are comfortable with where they are. I am here to

make you uncomfortable because God has made me uncomfortable. In this case discontentment can be a result of vision. We should be driven internally by a dream to accomplish everything God intended for us.

We should be believing God to “...*to do exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that works in us.*”

ILLUSTRATION: Sir Ernest Shackleton (1874 – 1922) was an Anglo-Irish Antarctic explorer, best known for leading the 'Endurance' expedition of 1914-16. While attempting to recruit men to explore the very dangerous Antarctic he is believed to have posted the following advertisement – “*Men wanted for hazardous journey. Low wages, bitter cold, long hours of complete darkness. Safe return*

doubtful. Honor and recognition in the case of success. ”

I pray that 2017 will be more than biding time and tending to menial chores. There are:

- Territories to explore..
- Accomplishments to be made...
- Adventures to be had...
- Glory to be gained...

Shackleton's decision and ambition transformed his life into one of notoriety. He was obviously not satisfied with, nor motivated by, ease and comfort, but craved something more adventurous. 2017 is going to be a year of adventure and conquest.

For the next three weeks we are going to focus on the CT Vision:

- Disciple...
- Empower...
- Serve...

GOING BEYOND THROUGH DISCIPLESHIP

Today, I want to look at “Going Beyond” in discipleship. The Lord defined Discipleship for me a few years ago. He said you haven’t made a disciple until:

- You have reached a person who does not know Christ...
- The new convert is actively engaged in the process of discipleship...
- The new convert has reached a person who does not know Christ...

- The new convert is actively engaged in the process of discipleship - with their new convert...

Jesus built the First Century Church on discipleship. He has COMMANDED us to be actively engaged in the process of discipleship. Matthew 28:18-20 (NKJV) ***“And Jesus came and spoke to them, saying, “All authority has been given to Me in heaven and on earth. Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all things that I have commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age.” Amen.”*** Jesus did not suggest discipleship He COMMANDED IT!

Therefore, in 2017 we are going to “Go Beyond” anything we have ever done before in this area.

Jesus did not come to establish a cute program; He came to launch a global movement. He came to establish a global enterprise of salvation and discipleship.

DISCIPLESHIP IS A CALL TO FOLLOW JESUS

Mark 1:16-18 (NKJV) *“And as He walked by the Sea of Galilee, He saw Simon and Andrew his brother casting a net into the sea; for they were fishermen. 17 Then Jesus said to them, “Follow Me, and I will make you become fishers of men.” 18 They immediately left their nets and followed Him.”*

Jesus changed the course of human history with a call for twelve men to follow Him. A call to follow Him is not necessarily an easy course. Luke 9:23 (NKJV) ***“Then He said to them all, ‘If anyone desires to come after Me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow Me.’”*** The call to discipleship is a call to:

- Self-denial...
- Cross bearing...
- Followership...

To “Go Beyond” in discipleship is to go much farther in these three disciplines! Are you ready? Are you sure?

I am believing God to ***“do exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think”*** in making disciples in 2017.

DISCIPLESHIP IS A CALL TO PERSONAL GROWTH AND MATURITY

The twelve men Jesus called would be the ones he would ultimately hand over the greatest movement known to man.

They began the journey as very immature disciples. They were:

- Uncultured...
- Rough cut...
- Self seeking...
- Hot tempered...
- Very impulsive...
- Pronged to jealousy...

Because Jesus spent the necessary time and treasure on them they ended well.

Discipleship is THE one thing the church has at its disposal to move people from immaturity to maturity. When this occurs the change not only affects the disciple, it affects every one in their circle of influence.

Though Jesus' disciples had a rough start they finished well:

- Andrew died on the cross...
- Simon was crucified...
- Bartholomew was flayed alive...
- James the son of Zebedee was beheaded...
- James the son of Alphaeus was beaten to death...
- Thomas was run through with a lance...
- Mathias was stoned and then beheaded...
- Matthew was slain by the sword...
- Peter was crucified upside down...

- Thaddeus was shot to death with arrows...
- Philip was hanged...
- Only John made it through alive but he was exiled to a small island in the middle of the Mediterranean Sea...

Are you ready to “Go Beyond” in discipleship?
Are you sure?

I am praying that God will “*do exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think*” in bringing us to maturity as believers in 2017.

DISCIPLESHIP IS A CALL TO LEAD OTHERS

Jesus was the Son of God, yet He recognized that He had to train others to do what He did, if He was going to change the world.

Changing the world seems like it would take more than twelve disciples. What Jesus launched and they (the 12) stewarded has:

- Changed the eternal destinies of millions...
- Altered the course of human culture, government, the arts and sciences...
- Brought about the building of countless houses of worship, hospitals, universities and charity organizations...
- Enlisted the largest volunteer army in the world with branches in nearly every corner of the globe...

A seemingly simple carpenter from Nazareth and twelve unskilled men launched all of this!

What if 2,000 people who call CT their church home decided to “Go Beyond” in discipleship in

2017? Only God knows the capability of such a group!

I am praying that God will “*do exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think*” as we lead people in 2017.

Are you ready to “Go Beyond” in discipleship in 2017? Are you sure?

CONCLUSION:

What does it look like to “Go Beyond” in discipleship at CT Church?

- Make a conscious effort to reach someone this year... (We have 8 weeks of Bible lessons ready for you this morning – Just ask someone to study the Bible with you for 8 weeks)

- Lead a life group... (Jesus changed the world with a life group – Surely we can change our neighborhood with one)
- Attend a life group... (At least attend a life group and make an honest effort to bring a person who doesn't know Christ with you)

GOING BEYOND THROUGH EMPOWERMENT

TEXT: Ephesians 3:20 (NKJV) *“Now to Him who is able to do exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that works in us.”*

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To “Go Beyond” we must first become discontent with the status quo. Very few people or organizations make progress when they are comfortable with where they are. The vision of “Going Beyond” should make us all uncomfortable. In this case discontentment is a result of vision. We should be driven to push through internal discomfort by a dream to accomplish everything God intended for us.

Last week we:

- Defined discipleship...
- Discussed Jesus’ call and expectation for discipleship...

- Considered the powerful impact that Jesus' twelve disciples had on the course of human history.

This week we will consider “Going Beyond” in Empowering others.

THE POWER SOURCE

As many of you know, I have worked for many years in home building. My father worked as a homebuilder to support our family while working as a pastor and I followed in his footsteps, and over the years did the same. I can assure you that much efficiency is to be gained when one can employ electric or gas powered tools as opposed to hand tools:

- Have you ever tried to remove a tree limb with an axe versus a chainsaw?
- Have you ever tried to cut lumber with a handsaw versus a skill saw?

- Have you ever tried to sand wood with a piece of sandpaper versus as power sander?
- Have you ever tried to install drywall screws with a screwdriver versus a power drill?

I could provide example after example, but I think you get the picture.

When plugged into power, and with the right tool in hand to connect to that power, we become exponentially more effective in completing the task at hand. We must be properly empowered if we are to become effective disciples for the Lord Jesus Christ.

A handsaw, though useful, is not configured to receive electrical power. Until we are born-again and surrendered to the Lordship of Jesus Christ, we are not configured to receive His power. Once we have been born-again, we must

get plugged into His ***“power that is at work in us.”*** [Ephesians 3:20] Zechariah 4:6 states so well, ***“It is not by might nor by power, but by My Spirit,’ Says the Lord of hosts.”***

THE POWER METHOD

We must ask ourselves the question ***“How did Jesus empower the twelve disciples?”*** Mark 3:13-15 (NKJV) ***“And He went up on the mountain and called to Him those He Himself wanted. And they came to Him. Then He appointed twelve, that they might be with Him and that He might send them out to preach, and to have power to heal sicknesses and to cast out demons.”*** Two things must be considered here:

- To be empowered, they had to ***“Be with Him.”*** If we are to be empowered we must:
 - (1) Spend time with Jesus – Have a personal devotional life. What time do you pray and

read your Bible each day? If you could not answer that within five seconds you probably don't have one. We will never have power without spending time with Him. (2) We must spend time being in the presence of our leaders being mentored by them. When we submit to be mentored by leaders we are agreeing that they can say what they want to, when they want to, how they want to, and we give up the right to be offended. This year CT Church is going to offer us the opportunity to be empowered through training. Will we take advantage of the opportunity?

- To be empowered we must receive power that is not a part of our human strength. Notice, Jesus gave His disciples ***“Power to heal sicknesses and to cast out demons.”*** How do we receive this power? Acts 1:8 (NKJV) ***“But you shall receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you; and***

you shall be witnesses to Me in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth.” When we accept Christ we are SEALED with the Holy Spirit; when we become baptized in the Holy Spirit we are FILLED with the Holy Ghost.

THE RESULT OF POWER

This power comes to us through the indwelling of the Holy Spirit. Acts 2:1-4 (NKJV) *“When the Day of Pentecost had fully come, they were all with one accord in one place. And suddenly there came a sound from heaven, as of a rushing mighty wind, and it filled the whole house where they were sitting. Then there appeared to them divided tongues, as of fire, and one sat upon each of them. And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak with other tongues, as the Spirit gave them utterance.”*

From Acts two forward, the book of Acts is a highlight reel of:

- The exploits of the Spirit... (Signs, miracles & wonders)
- The perseverance of the believers... (Before the crucifixion the disciples denied Jesus – After Pentecost they endured hardship, persecution and death but NEVER denied Him)
- The expansion of the Gospel... (Acts 2 is the birthday of the church – The first day 3,000 accepted Christ – The soul winning enterprise of the First Century Church continued until the counting stopped and the Scripture say's "***He added to the church daily, such as should be saved.***")

Soul winning is the initial trait of a church empowered by the Spirit! "***When you receive***

the Holy Ghost – You SHALL become witnesses.” Signs miracles and wonders are hallmarks of empowered churches and empowered believers, but soul winning is the benchmark.

CONCLUSION:

Think of this, if twelve people in this church would commit to winning one person a year, and making that convert into a disciple who brings a person a year to Christ, over a twenty year period, 12,582,900 would be won to the Lord!

CT Church is a Pentecostal church! Our aim is to expose you to the precious presence of the Holy Spirit, and inspire you to open the door of your heart to allow Him to FILL you and EMPOWER you. He is here today to do just that.

In just a moment we are going to ask everyone who has never received the infilling of the Spirit to come forward to receive power. When you come forward here is what you can expect to happen: (Read Acts 19:6 (Paul at Ephesus)

“When Paul had laid hands on them, the Holy Spirit came upon them, and they spoke with tongues and prophesied.)

- We are going to lay our hands on you and pray... (Paul did this and this is what we are going to do)
- The Holy Spirit is going to come on you... (When He comes upon you, words you have never learned and do not understand are going to begin to pop into your mind – Don’t be afraid – That is the Holy Spirit)
- You are going to speak in a language you have not learned previously... (You will not understand the words – You must just be obedient and speak them – You will never

understand those words – They are the language of Heaven)

GOING BEYOND THROUGH SERVING

TEXT: Ephesians 3:20 (NKJV) *“Now to Him who is able to do exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that works in us.”*

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One of the definitions of serve on dictionary.com is: “*To be of use.*” If we serve others, we are in fact being of use to them.

INDIVIDUAL SERVICE

Just notice, the next time you drive down any street, the variety of establishments you will pass by:

- Schools...
- Restaurants...
- Auto repair shops...
- Clothing stores...
- Hardware stores...
- Fire stations...
- Law offices...
- Construction crews...

All these are providing a service! If we think about it, serving is all around us!

One of the greatest examples of corporate service is found in the First Century Church when the office of Deacon was established.

We've discussed the past two Sundays the powerful reach and impact of the ministry of Jesus' Twelve Disciples. Through His initiative and their stewardship, the greatest enterprise in the history of mankind was launched – the Church! But even these great apostles could not accomplish the task of spreading the gospel and ministering to the people of God without a team around them to help meet needs so they appointed Deacons. (Acts 6:1-7)

The word “deacon” means “servant.” Notice the qualifications of the deacon/servant:

- A person full of the Holy Spirit...
- A person filled with wisdom...
- A person of good reputation...
- A person whose attitude models the fruit of the Spirit...

Some would say, “*I must wait until I am qualified to serve,*” but the key is to start somewhere and work your way into the place your gifts and anointing suit you to serve.

Are you ready to “Go Beyond” in serving in 2017? Are you sure?

THE POWER TO SERVE

Our Scripture text, reminds us that God acts through the power that is at work in us!

Titus 2:14 (NKJV) reminds us that Jesus, “... ***gave Himself for us, that He might redeem us from every lawless deed and purify for Himself His own special people, zealous for good works.***” Notice this, Jesus:

- Redeemed us from every lawless deed... (I’m saved and I know that I am)
- Redeemed us to purity... (Sanctified us)
- Redeemed us to good works... (We are not saved by works - We will be judged for our works sake – We are redeemed from a sinful state to our original destiny)

It is true that Jesus redeemed us to save us eternally but His redemption is also intended to realign us with His initial purpose for our lives.

His power is at work in us and this results in the zeal to serve. Babe Ruth said, *“It's hard to beat a person who never gives up.”*

The fullest expression of Christianity is in fact to serve God and others with zeal. The power working in us drives us to serve Him and to advance His kingdom interests with passion and fervency.

How can we say that we are redeemed by Jesus, the greatest servant in human history, and are indwelt by His Holy Spirit whose power is at work in us, and not ourselves be servants?

Philippians 2:5-11 (NKJV) “Let this mind be in you which was also in Christ Jesus, who, being in the form of God, did not consider it robbery to be equal with God, but made Himself of no reputation, taking the form of a bondservant, and coming in the likeness of

men. And being found in appearance as a man, He humbled Himself and became obedient to the point of death, even the death of the cross. Therefore, God also has highly exalted Him and given Him the name which is above every name, that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of those in heaven, and of those on earth, and of those under the earth, and that every tongue should confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.” Jesus modeled servant-hood in the following ways:

- He made Himself of no reputation... (He laid aside his Kingly robe to put on an earth suit)
- He took upon Himself the role of a servant... (He humbled Himself to become useful to others – He washed the feet of the disciples)

- He took upon Himself human form...
(Traded an eternal priesthood for a body subject to human maladies)
- He was obedient unto death, even the death of the cross... (In the face of the most horrible suffering He still continued forward in accomplishing the Father's plan – Serving all of us)

The Scripture admonished us, “*Let this mind be in you.*” “*Let...*” means that this is something I must submit my will to, not what He is going to make me do! Servant-hood is as much an attitude as an activity!

Are you ready to allow the Holy Spirit to empower you to serve in 2017? Are you sure?

SERVING ON A TEAM

Today is Super bowl Sunday, which brings me to the idea of team-servant-hood. Football is not an individual sport it is a team sport:

- How much success do you think a quarterback would have if he had no offensive line?
- How many games do you think a high-powered offense would win without a defense?
- How many games do you think a stingy defense would win if they had no offense?
- What good would it be to have an offense and defense without a coach to put it all together?

Runners will gain no significant yardage if linemen do not block. Quarterbacks will fail to complete passes if receivers drop the ball.

Who knows, the entire game's final outcome might rest upon the foot of a kicker! The greatest kicker in the world cannot complete his task without a proper snap, a proper hold and solid blocking up front.

I am going to tell you who will win the Super bowl today! The franchise that plays with the best team effort will win!

The same is true of the church. It is through serving others, through making ourselves useful to others, that we find group and individual success and joy.

An anonymous author once said, *“Teamwork divides the task and multiplies the success.”* John Maxwell said, *“Teamwork makes the dream work.”*

Founding Father Benjamin Franklin has been quoted as saying concerning the risks they took in revolting against England, “*We must all hang together or most assuredly we shall hang separately.*”

One unknown author said, “*Teamwork is essential — it allows you to blame someone else.*” People who serve with a team mentality are quick to accept blame and share the credit.

Think of the ingredients of a great recipe:

- Some are bitter...
- Some are sweet...
- Some smell good...
- Some smell bad...
- Some look delicious...
- Some look repulsive...

In the hands of a master chef, mixed together and exposed to the heat of the stove or the oven, they become blended together and their differences can become complimentary and produce something that sustains life and brings pleasure. Great spaghetti has many ingredients and is better as a leftover because its ingredients blend over time.

If we have the mind of Christ – and be willing to serve and endure the heat together, He will blend us together into a sweet smelling and flavorful offering!

If we, as a team, will pull together toward a common goal of serving others, Christ will coach us through to the championship!

If we are going to fulfill the will of the Father, we must make ourselves useful to others.

Are you ready to “Go Beyond” in serving in 2017? Are you sure?

CONCLUSION:

I am asking you to do the following things:

- 1) If you are serving, keep up the good work!
- 2) If you are not serving, begin today!
- 3) If you have not completed the connect track, please do so!
- 4) If you have not taken the place test, please do so!

**LIFE GROUP FACILITATORS
QUESTIONS**

- 1) Read Ephesians 3:20
- 2) What are the three main points of the CT Vision? (Disciple – Empower – Serve)
- 3) What does discipleship involve in the context of the CT Vision? (It involves reaching the lost – Getting new converts into a new believers class – Connecting them to a life group – Getting new believers to attend a Freedom Weekend - Helping them reach out to their un-churched friends with the intention of leading them to Christ and discipling them)
- 4) What does empowering people look like in the context of the CT Vision? (CT is committed to empowering people by preaching and teaching the Word of God at all of its campuses and venues – Each first Saturday of the month leadership

training will be offered – Several times a year Leadership Summits will be held on Sunday evenings – We will encourage each believer to be empowered by the Holy Spirit in their every day life)

- 5) What does serving mean in the context of the CT Vision? (We will serve each other with the spirit of Christ likeness Read Galatians 6:10 – We will serve our community through food fairs – Health fairs – Partnering with local schools and community groups – Working to provide for homeless students in local school systems – etc... - We will not only serve individually but we will serve as a team – More can be accomplished over the long haul if we work together – We will adopt the quote by John Maxwell “*Teamwork makes the dream work*”)